

AS/A Level Media Studies - Set Product Fact Sheet

- A sexually attractive femme fatale functioning as a strong protagonist, until the end
- Disillusioned, flawed anti-hero (detective), often with a past
- Claustrophobic and menacing setting; closed frames to connote entrapment; canted angles suggesting disorientation
- A slow pace
- Moral decline and ambiguity with a focus on the darker elements of life
- Themes of corruption, greed, obsession, duality, isolation
- Strong awareness of mortality and irony of human existence
- Complex narrative and convoluted plot
- Iconography – bars created by shadows through blinds, cigarettes, neon, rain, alleyways, trench coat and trilby.

Theoretical Approach: Genre – Steve Neale

- Neale asserts that genres may be dominated by repetition, but they are also marked by difference, variation, and change. Crime dramas have a recognisable repertoire of elements that place them in the genre, but to appeal to audiences they need to display something different to set them apart from other examples. Difference is essential to sustain a genre, to simply repeat the codes and conventions of the form would not appeal to an audience.
- In *The Bridge*, the Scandinavian setting, locations, and the enigmatic character of Saga proved novel for audiences.
- *The Bridge* demonstrates that genres change, develop, and vary as they borrow from and overlap with one another. Some contemporary crime dramas are less easy to categorise as they are hybrid genres and this variation consequently enhances audience appeal. *The Bridge* as an example of the Nordic Noir sub-genre, borrows conventions from film noir.
- Genres exist within specific economic, institutional, and industrial contexts. The recognisable codes and conventions of crime dramas make them easy to market to audiences. However, subverting and challenging these conventions by introducing more novel elements as in *The Bridge* can also ensure commercial success.

The Bridge demonstrates typical elements of a police procedural crime drama, but also, as Neale has suggested, incorporates differences illustrating the dynamic and socially relative nature of genre conventions and the hybridity of the genre:

- Nordic noir/ Film Noir elements
- Elements of the action genre, for example the chase scene
- Horror conventions, for example the build-up of tense music, audio codes suggesting supernatural elements, slow turning to camera and the execution of the crime
- Elements of the psychological thriller, for example the murder scene, the slow pace, and the use of silence/ lack of dialogue
- Gender representations – there are stock characters and representations we expect in a crime drama, but strong female roles challenging expectations. Saga is an unusual heroine, she is flawed but central to the narrative, with unpredictable and interesting behaviour traits.
- Setting and aesthetic, intensity of mood and dark, unsettling themes
- Technical codes which reference film noir, for example the low-key lighting, the use of torchlight, profile shots and intense close-ups and frames with isolated figures
- The unique setting, the bridge, represents the 'other-worldly' which links cultures but is neither one place nor another, shots of the bridge are used throughout the episode
- The narrative of the stylised murders referencing "art" and notions of the surreal.

How the combination of elements of media language influence meaning. Consider:

Visual codes:

- **Codes of clothing:** The connotations of characters' clothing and appearance create meanings. Clothing is a rapid way of communicating messages in *The Bridge*. Saga's versions of the same outfit and colour scheme contribute to the enigma surrounding her character and her behaviour traits. Clothing worn by the other detectives is informal and functional, unlike UK crime dramas clothing does not connote a hierarchy within the police force.
- **Gesture and expression:** non-verbal communicators are quick ways of constructing meaning. *The Bridge* frequently uses close-up shots of characters to communicate meaning and many of the expressions are serious, anxious, and fearful, reflecting the dark themes and melancholy aesthetic. Saga's passive expression rarely changes, and it is only after the explosion and in the final scenes of this episode where she is confronted with her mother, that she is seen to be disconcerted, confused and afraid.
- **Iconography and Setting:** props, backgrounds and settings work together to construct the narrative.